Chapter 9: The Dreaded Meeting

In the comfortably cool air of the mid-September afternoon, Noah and I were on one of the pathways walking to our meeting. Both of us were nearly shaking with nervousness. Our hands clutched together trying to calm each other. Unfortunately for both of us, it didn't seem to be working. The scene in Maria's lab whirled around in my head. What did Noah mean when he said that he was my bratty slave? Why would he say I was training him? My grip on his hand tightened as I thought about all of it.
"What's wrong?" Noah asked, sensing the tension in my body.
"You mean besides the fact that we're going to tell admin about us, and the fact I'm risking my career to date you?" I answered.
"Yes. That's obvious. I feel the same way on that part, but something else is bothering you, I can tell. Tell me… please – I don't like it."
"Well… a couple of things you said in the lab are kind of bothering me. That's all."
"Come on, tell me what's bothering you," he probed. "It's safe, we're outside and nobody's around. Everyone's in class for another hour."
I quickly looked around us, the emptiness of the campus giving me a small bit of reassurance to discuss what he said. "You told the group you were my bratty slave. What's that mean?" I asked him.
He laughed quietly. "Right, you're still new to this," he said. "A brat is a type of submissive in the BDSM community. A submissive that pushes back – they won't follow directions unless they're told a few times… or even punished."

"That's a thing?" I asked.
"*Everything's* a thing, Cameron. Literally everything. We're a nerd and a jock. That's a thing too, you know."
"But you're not a brat – you've never pushed back."
"I'm not a brat *yet*. Trust me, I'm *definitely* a brat. You're not ready – we're not ready – for that to come out. We're getting there, but we're not quite there yet."
"What do you mean, we're not ready?" I asked.
"Our relationship is still too new. Give it a while, it'll come out when the time is right. You'll see."
"Hopefully it comes out sooner rather than later… I want to experience it."
"Oh really? Maybe you are ready… I'll tell you what, if it feels right, I'll try being bratty during our next scene. How's that?"
"That sounds nice… I'll take it." My hands slightly loosened now that part of the experience was handled. The other still whirled around in my brain, and I could tell that Noah still felt it.
"What else? You're still tense. Something else is bothering you."
"You also mentioned something about training? What's that about?"

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“That’s another thing in BDSM. You’re a Master Dom – you order me around, I listen. I serve you. For me to do it right, you need to train me. Tell me how you want me to do it, and what happens if I don’t.”
“We haven’t done anything like that yet.”
“Right… we’re still new. It takes time to develop. If you’re *really* interested in the master/slave dynamic, you can start training me whenever you want. How ever you want. You have my permission.”
“I don’t need your permission, *slave boy*,” I whispered. My face lit up with a grin as I said that. Noah’s did too as his body shook with excitement.
“Yes, master,” he whispered back. My hand lost all its tension, my grip on his returning to the soft, romantic state we both loved.

We were about halfway to the other side of the campus by now, both of us just holding the other’s hand and admiring the cool air and the scenery around the campus. I was secretly admiring Noah too – all forms of him. Something inside me also hoped that he was doing the same for me. I wanted to ask, but I thought the suspense helped my nerves. About another five minutes later, we reached the administration building. It looked ominous, like this is where students came to have their lives ruined and where all the darkness on the campus lived. We approached the main entrance and Noah’s hand tightened up. “Nervous?” I asked.
“Yeah. I like what we have. I don’t want anyone to break us up. I don’t want you to lose your job. I want us to stay as we are. Do… do we really have to do this?”
“You know we do. Maybe they’ll be okay with it. Maybe they won’t. We won’t know until we ask. Plus, if we don’t tell them and we get caught, it’ll be much worse than if we told them now.”
“I know… I just wish it wasn’t so…”
“Gloomy?” I said softly, finishing his sentence.
“Yeah… gloomy.”
“Me too… This building has always freaked me out. Shall we?” I asked.
“We don’t really have a choice. We might as well just get it over with.”
We stood outside the brown metal door for a few seconds, just staring at the sign hanging from a welded screw in the middle, which read “University Administration” in block letters. We both started shaking, nervous about what was about to happen.
“Whatever happens,” I started. I tightened my grip on Noah’s hand. This time, it wasn’t in worry or in anxiousness. It was in love. “I still love you,” I whispered.
Noah tightened his grip on me and whispered back, “I love you too, Cameron.”

Together, we took one last deep breath before mustering up the courage to pull the door open. We entered the building in unison, our worries slightly soothed by our small profession of love. I placed my hand on the reception desk as we approached, our grip on each other slipping by the nanosecond. “Cameron Thorpe and Noah Harper to see Roger Windrow, Human Resources,” I said in a calm, professional tone.

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“Yes – I see that meeting on our calendar. Please wait in the waiting area, someone will be with you shortly to bring you in,” the receptionist said. She pressed a button slightly to her side, opening the door to the back area of the building. We both thanked her as we entered, finding the waiting area and heading directly towards it. Of course, we sat right next to each other, completely silent, our hands once again finding each other on the armrests between our seats. I could only take deep breaths, trying to calm my nerves for what we were about to go through. Talking about our relationship with Maria, Braeden and Mitchell was one thing. I could handle that – even though it was slightly uncomfortable. I trusted them. Nothing would go wrong if I told them. This… this was different. Telling administration felt like confessing to a crime. It didn’t feel safe at all, and that’s what was worrying me.

Sitting in the waiting area, the thoughts started to drive themselves back into my mind. *What if they say we can’t be together? What if they expel him? What if they fire me on the spot?* All of these thoughts just made the nerves even worse. I think Noah could feel the tension building inside me, so he broke the silence.
“It’ll be okay, Cam…” he said, his hand grasping mine. “Whatever happens, we’ll deal with it, together. Think about us – just me and you.”
“I know what you’re trying to do, and I appreciate it, but it’s not working,” I said, my voice quiet yet piercing with nervousness and anger. “How can I think of anything else when our futures just lie in the balance of the next half an hour?”
“I know… but try. Try for me. Please?” he asked.
“Fine. But I need some help.”
“I’ve got you, don’t worry,” he said softly. He cuddled up to me slightly, rested his head on my shoulders, and started drawing small circles on my palm with his thumb. “Deep breaths,” he said, coaching me through the same de-stressing routine I’d already been trying. Every time I breathed in; he did the same. Every time I breathed out, he was there, almost perfectly synchronized to my body and its reaction. “Good, Cam, Good,” he said, encouraging me to continue.

We sat there in silence, just cuddling the small amount we could, breathing together. I can’t be sure exactly how much time had passed, but we were eventually called back. “Cameron and Noah?” I heard in the distance. We both stood up slowly, our hands gradually drifting apart. Neither of us liked it, but we both knew that we shouldn’t show any sort of affection. At least until after this meeting. “Please follow me,” the voice said. The staff led us through what seemed like a maze of hallways before showing us into a small conference room. We both took one more deep breath before we sat at opposite ends of the long table in the center of the room. Being away from him, the boy I loved with all my heart and soul, felt absolutely horrible. It felt like our existence was suddenly forbidden. It felt like we were both about to be absolutely chewed out, destroyed, and thrown out like garbage. I was ready to burst into tears – I almost couldn’t handle the stress, the anxiousness of just sitting in the room.

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Not too long after we sat down, the person we were here to see appeared at the door, followed by both the dean of my faculty and the dean of Noah's. We both quickly stood as they entered the room and approached the other side of the table.
"Please be seated," Mr. Windrow said, oddly calmly. Given the nature of what we were discussing, I expected everyone to be quite serious, even slightly crass. All five of us sat down, and Mr. Windrow got his laptop out of its carry case, set it in the table and opened it. "We are here to discuss a potential relationship between Dr. Cameron Thorpe and Mr. Noah Harper, correct?" he asked.
"Yes, sir. I am Cameron, and this is Noah," I answered, voice shaking with nervousness.
"Thank you for that, Dr. Thorpe. I am Roger Windrow, faculty relations supervisor for the human resources department, and with me is Dr. Penny Chesterton, dean of the Turing Faculty of Computer Science, and Dr. Andrew Peng, dean of the Faculty of Humanities," he continued.
"Before we begin, I realize that just being in front of an administration panel can be a bit nerve-wracking, so I want to clarify that this is not a disciplinary meeting at all. We're here just to hear both sides of the story and to see if we can come to an amicable middle ground. Yes?" We both nodded, daring not to speak in case something went wrong, despite what was just said. For some reason, we didn't believe it.
"Good, so please tell us how this came to fruition," he asked.

"Well," I started. I cleared my throat and shifted in my seat. "Noah and I have known each other since we were little. We went to middle school and high school together in Vancouver, during which time we became very close."
"Then, we applied here together, and we were both accepted. We moved from Vancouver to Waterloo together to attend classes. At this point, we were still close friends," Noah continued.
"Okay, I'm not hearing anything particularly concerning yet," said Dr. Peng.
"Well… that's not the end of it," I said. "As we both progressed through our programs, we remained good friends. I ended up pursuing both graduate and terminal degrees while Noah was playing for our hockey team and finishing his classes."
"That's when our situation kind of… turned upside down. It was at a party after the convocation this past year. We were… let's just say… getting even closer during a dare, which led to us being…" Noah slowly got out.
"*Intimate* with each other," I interrupted.
"I see…" Mr. Windrow said.
"Everything was consensual," Noah quickly chimed in, "if anyone was thinking I was coerced or forced into it, that's not what happened."
"Nobody is accusing anyone of that," Dr. Chesterton reassured us. "We're just trying to hear the story so we can make an informed decision and work out some terms with you both. That's all."
"Is there anything else either of you would like to add?" Mr. Windrow asked.
"We talked, and as it turns out both of us have romantic feelings for each other," I started.
"We… decided to start a relationship," Noah finished.

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“Now I see why we’re here…” Windrow said, slowly typing on his laptop.
“What are our options at this point?” I asked. “Our relationship is going very well for the both of us so far, and it’s helped me get into a better head space after all the research I’ve done. I look forward to going home to him after a long day of teaching.”
“If there are any options that would allow us to keep our relationship while still respecting the integrity of the university, we’re more than happy to hear them,” Noah agreed.
“Well… this does put the university in a rather difficult position,” Windrow started. “However, the university doesn’t want to get in the way of students’ or employees’ lives. I have spoken to doctors Chesterton and Peng at length over the past couple of days to get you some options, and we’ve agreed on what we believe will be amicable to the both of you,” he continued. He slid a thin bundle of paper across the table to each of us. I glanced down at it, and the first thing I saw were the words “Waiver of Conflict of Interest – Acknowledgement of Relationship.”
“What’s… this?” I asked slowly.
“In the legal world, it’s considered a love contract. In essence, it’s just a document that shows we were made aware of your relationship, that we went through the terms of how it affects both of you at the university, and that you agree to follow them,” Dr. Chesterton calmly explained.
“We’ll give the two of you some time to read it over and discuss things before you make your decision,” Windrow said. He, Dr. Chesterton and Dr. Peng stood and exited the room, leaving the two of us sitting at the table, staring at the document.
“Well, that went well, I guess,” Noah said.
“We’re not done yet. We’ve got to figure out what we’re doing. Let’s just read through it, then we can talk.”

We both started to slowly go through the document, turning pages as we read them. I occasionally saw Noah flip to previous pages before continuing. There were sections in there about how we told the university, listing many conditions that I needed to meet – and many more that Noah needed to meet – to keep our relationship university-legal. Mine were what I expected: no teaching him, no involvement in any academic matters involving him or any of his classes, no discussing his academic record with anyone… the standard stuff. Noah’s were similar, he couldn’t take any of my classes or ask me to intervene for him for anything. Then, there were a few more about what we could and couldn’t do together, which basically boiled down to no public displays of overly sexualized affection, and tell as few people as possible. What followed was the part that scared me – what could happen if any of these terms were violated. For Noah, it could lead to severe sanctions, like being suspended or expelled, and for me, it could lead to being put on leave until he graduates or being outright fired. I didn’t want anything like that to happen – to either of us. It took us about fifteen minutes to read through everything. Once I saw Noah finish reading through his copy, I looked at him and asked, “So, what do you think?” and waited anxiously for his answer. He sat there in silence for about a minute, one hand covering his

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mouth, the other tapping the document as it lay in front of him on the table. Eventually, he swiveled his chair around, facing himself towards me.
“You know what, Cam,” he started, staring into my eyes as if he was lost in them. “I think we can handle this.”
“But… just look at what can happen if—” I started to point out, spiralling into a nosedive of worried feelings, almost ready to end the relationship I was so desperate to start.
“Cam,” he said, rolling his chair closer to me. “We can handle this. Trust me. I won’t let any of that happen to you, and I know you won’t let any of it to happen to me. You know I trust you… do you trust me?” he asked, carefully taking my hand in his.
“I do… but—” I continued to spiral.
“Then, let’s do it. I see no problems as long as we do what they ask. At least I get to keep you.”
“I’ll do anything to keep you, Noah. I’ve always known I would.”
“Me too… does that mean—" he started to ask.
“Let’s do it,” I answered, shaking with worry.
“Good – let’s keep—” Noah started.
“Each other,” we both said at the same time. We stared at each other, smiling and holding hands.

Shortly after we made our decision, the others came back in the room. “We’ve decided to accept the terms of this agreement. We both think our relationship is too valuable to lose,” I blurted out the second the door closed.
“We thought you would. You both read through the terms?” Dr. Peng asked.
“Yes. We agree to all of them. I just don’t want to give him up,” Noah answered instantly.
“And I don’t want to give him up,” I added.
“Alright then,” Windrow started. “All we need to do now is sign them.” He reached back into his bag and pulled out two more copies of the contract.
“Four copies?” Noah asked.
“Those two you will keep, and these two the university will keep. One goes into your record, and the other goes into Cameron’s personnel file.”
“Okay… does anyone have a pen?” Noah continued. I couldn’t help but smile – if he was this eager to sign these contracts, he was serious about making our relationship work. Just as serious as I was. And that made me feel like I – we – made the right decision. I took the pen out of my jacket pocket as Windrow slid one to Noah across the table. After the two or three minutes of all five of us shifting all four copies of the contract around the table, Noah asked, “so… so, that’s it? We can still be together?”
“The university has no issues with it as long as the terms of the agreement are followed,” Dr. Chesterton said softly.

The others got up again and left the room, once again leaving the two of us in the room alone. I was relieved that the meeting was over, but having a load of restrictions put onto our relationship made it feel like we were a commodity being imported to a different country. I couldn’t read how

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Noah felt, which for me was normal, but I could occasionally pick up a small cue from him.
“Well, that went better than I thought it would,” I remarked as we left the room.
“Yeah… I didn’t think it would go well – but it did. I still have you, so that’s the best way it could have went.”
“Aww, you’re cute. I feel the same way. I’m glad I didn’t lose you. I don’t know what I would have done.”
Noah’s face lit up with a grin at my complement. “Let’s not go there. We don’t have to, so let’s just… *not*.”
“Agreed. Let’s figure out how to get out of here so we can go home and just cuddle together. We need it after that.”
“I’m on board for some cuddles, as long as we can play a bit too.”
“I guess that’s okay, Let’s get out of here. All this gloom is starting to get to me,” I said. We took a few minutes to navigate the maze we came in from, the occasional ‘exit this way’ signs guiding us. The second we stepped out of the main building door, we both took a deep breath – not in preparation for the worst, but filled with relief, celebrating the fact that we were still together.

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